connectivity. This, somehow, had not been expected by the British and was not stated in the original railway blueprint of British India, and led to lengthy debates in the British Parliament.

THE BIG-RAIL-SMALL-RAIL DEBATE

Many were against the small trains and many favoured it. Here are a few arguments that cropped up during the time:

Arguments against Small Trains

A resolution was moved in the House of Commons on Friday, 7 March 1873, that,

> It is contrary to Imperial policy to allow a break of gauge in the Railway communications between the important frontier town of Peshawar and the main railway system of India.

Laing, who moved the resolution, said,

> It was my objective to prevent a misfortune of national magnitude, a break of gauge in the Indian railway system at a point which was most important from a military point of view, and which might be regarded, in fact, as the Metz of India. [76]
>
> During his viceroyalty, Lord Mayo, one of the most able and popular of the many great Governor Generals of India, became impressed with the great advantages conferred by the railways, and arrived at the conclusion that 10,000 additional miles of railway were urgently needed to supplement the first and main trunk system of 5,000 miles, which had by then been completed. For the execution of such work, with economy of construction being obviously necessary, the Government of India had adopted what was called the metre gauge, of 3 feet 3 inches for the lines of the new system, by which it was estimated that £1,000 per mile would be saved on their cost.
>
> The superior economy of the proposed break of gauge—though advocated by two distinguished officers of Public Works in India—was, however, unanimously disputed by great railway engineers and managers. Mr Hawkshaw, one of the most eminent engineers in the world, had predicted that the Indian government would have to spend more money in remedying the evil of a break of gauge than they would save by introducing it. That prophecy was confirmed by the experiences of all countries into which a break of gauge had been introduced, and especially by what had happened in our own Great Western Railway.
>
> If one thing more than another contributed to the astounding success of the Germans, it was the fact that they were able to do that which we were about to preclude ourselves from doing in India—namely, to bring up their troops and supplies from the centre of their forces and reserves to the scene of operations. From Berlin to the Rhine, their lines had an unbroken gauge. There was a break of gauge at Metz, and in order to surmount it, the Germans constructed a circular railway. [77]